

Scripture for the hospital room

Eight passages that hold up at a bedside, and a few words to say with them. Read one. Then stop. Presence matters more than words.

BEFORE SURGERY

Isaiah 41:10

“Don’t you be afraid, for I am with you. Don’t be dismayed, for I am your God. I will strengthen you. Yes, I will help you. Yes, I will uphold you with the right hand of my righteousness.”

Five promises in one verse, said to people who had every reason to be afraid. The last one is a hand.

Exodus 33:14

“He said, “My presence will go with you, and I will give you rest.”

God’s answer to Moses when Moses was afraid to go forward without him. The presence goes in with you.

Psalms 4:8

“In peace I will both lay myself down and sleep, for you, Yahweh alone, make me live in safety.”

For the night before. Sleep is possible because someone else is on watch.

WAITING FOR NEWS

Psalms 112:7

“He will not be afraid of evil news. His heart is steadfast, trusting in Yahweh.”

A heart steady before the result, not after it.

Philippians 4:6-7

“In nothing be anxious, but in everything, by prayer and petition with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your thoughts in Christ Jesus.”

Not a feeling but a practice: each worry turned into a request, with thanks. The peace stands guard.

A LONG STAY

Matthew 11:28-30

“Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you, and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart; and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light.”

For the patient and for the exhausted family in the chair. The rest on offer is a burden that fits.

Psalms 23:1-4

“Yahweh is my shepherd: I shall lack nothing. He makes me lie down in green pastures. He leads me beside still waters. He restores my soul. He guides me in the paths of righteousness for his name’s sake. Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me. Your rod and your staff, they comfort me.”

Confident because of the shepherd, not because the road is safe.

WHEN THERE ARE NO WORDS

Psalms 34:18

“Yahweh is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit.”

Near to the brokenhearted. It asks nothing of the person but being broken. Read it and sit down.

WHAT TO SAY

- Arriving: “I don’t have anything wise to say. I just wanted to be here.”
- Offering a verse: “Can I read you something short? You don’t have to say anything back.”
- Leaving: “I’ll be back Thursday. You don’t need to remember that; I will.”

WHAT NOT TO SAY

- × “Everything happens for a reason.” “God won’t give you more than you can handle.” Neither is in the Bible, and both put the weight back on the person in the bed.

HOW TO USE THIS

Read one. Then stop. Presence matters more than words.